

Tutorial Class for 2023

Graduate Class

Social Policy and Planning

Focus Area (Learning Outcome)

- ✓ Understand the concept and principle of social policy
- ✓ Understand elements and steps in the formulation and analysis of social policy
- ✓ Clearly understand the relationship between policy and planning
- ✓ Well-versed with the strengths and weakness of different social planning approaches

Concepts and Principle of Social Policy

What is Social Policy

Let you look at how some scholars define it (video discussion)

Definition...

- **Policy** refers to a plan of action, statement of aims and ideals specially one made by a government, political party, business company, etc.
- **Social policy** can be defined in different ways. In one sense it can be defined as the aims of a group of citizens on a particular problem.
- **For example** we can talk of family policy, health policy, education policy, etc. It can also be defined as a set of programs developed either by government or private organizations to deliver particular welfare services.

Definition...

- Social policy' is just one specific aspect of the larger field of policy formulation. A state may have many types of policies.
- For example, foreign policy, finance and trade policy, military or defence policy, revenue policy, education policy, youth policy, population policy, labor policy and many other policies, these are working in different ways in different fields.
- Among these policies, those which are related to social problems and the normal life of the mass people are considered to be subject to specific boundaries of social policy. In particular, a policy will be considered a social policy if it is directly and indirectly related to social problems.

Cont..

- **Social policy** is the strategy of action indicating means and methods to be followed in successive phases to achieve the declared social objectives.

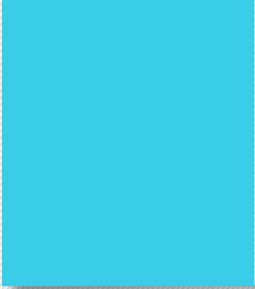
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- Definitions of Social Policy According to David Gill:
Social policies are principles/course of action designed to influence:
 - i. the overall quality of life in a society;
 - ii. the circumstances of living of individuals and groups in that society; and
 - iii. the nature of intra- societal relationships among individuals, groups and society as a whole.

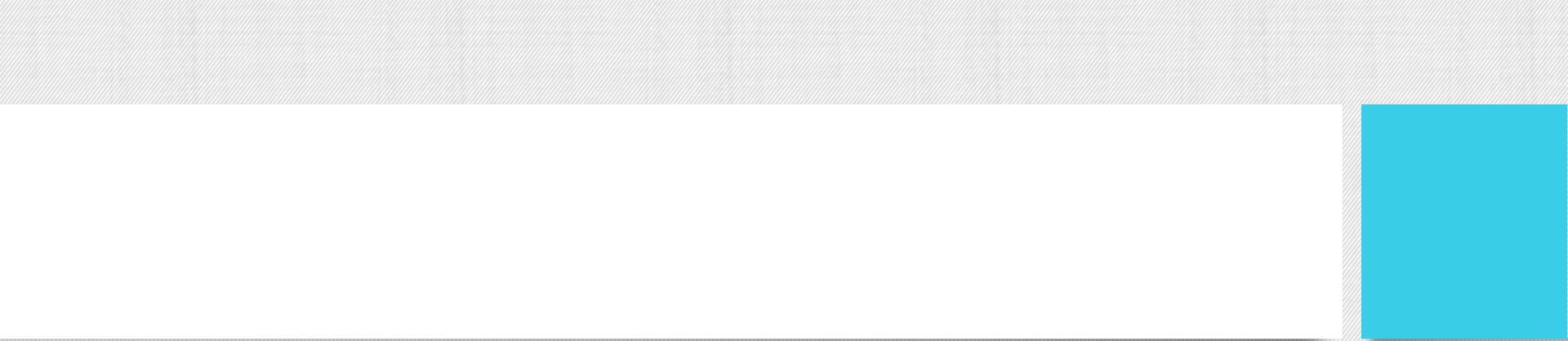
Objective of Social Policy

- Objective of social policy is minimization of sufferings and maximization of welfare.
- According to Midgley (2004), the **objective of social policy** include:
 1. **Poverty** reduction/alleviation
 2. Social **protection** (service provisions, safety net, micro-credit)
 3. Social **inclusion** (integrating marginalized groups)
 4. Promotion of **human rights** (right based approaches)
 5. Conserving the **natural resources**
- Generally, the **main objective** of social policy is the **achievement** of a **good life** to citizens through different services.

Principles of Social Policy



Values, Principles and Ideology of Social Policy



Conceptualizing Principles, Values, and Ideology ?

Principle

- **Is a general statement or tenet forming the ground of, or held to be essential to, a system of thought or belief;** or a fundamental assumption forming on the basis of a chain of reasoning.
- **a general set of values into tenets guiding the formulation of doctrine and of policy.**

Cont..

- **Some of the principles and values** which are applied to social policy are: **equity, equality, efficiency, security, liberty, rights, social justice, empowerment, diversity, solidarity, and citizenship.**
- How a society **defines** these **concepts** will directly **affect** the contours (shape) of the **policies** it creates.

Cont..

- ✓ **Equity** – **fairness** in the distribution of something;
- ✓ **Equality**- is seen as **distribution of opportunities**, in the sense of **equal treatment** or **consideration**.
- ✓ **Liberty** – freedom from **interference** in making choices. **Liberty** and **equality** affect each other. Taken to their **extremes** both freedom and equality are similarly **despotic** and **tyrannical** in their effects.

Cont..

- ✓ **Efficiency** – attaining the *most value* for the *least cost*.
- ✓ **Security** – extent to w/c **people's needs** are met as a function of government (materials; immediate, direct needs for survival; future needs; relational needs,...)
- ✓ **Social justice** – begins with presumption of equality; **people should not be treated differently without a reason**. It is about *fare share*.

Cont..

✓ **Rights and needs**

- ***Rights***- are rules can **protect liberties** or **impose duties** on other people.
- ***Needs***- things which people **must** have; it has implications to rights.

✓ **Empowerment**

- is a **means** both for **meeting needs/satisfying rights**.
- is it an empowering one? - ***the agency*** (the individual) and/ or the ***opportunity structure*** (the environment)?

Cont..

✓ **Diversity and difference**

- in culture & ethnicity, gender, political values and beliefs.
- **pluralistic** Vs. **particularistic** principles; **just** discrimination Vs. **unjust** one

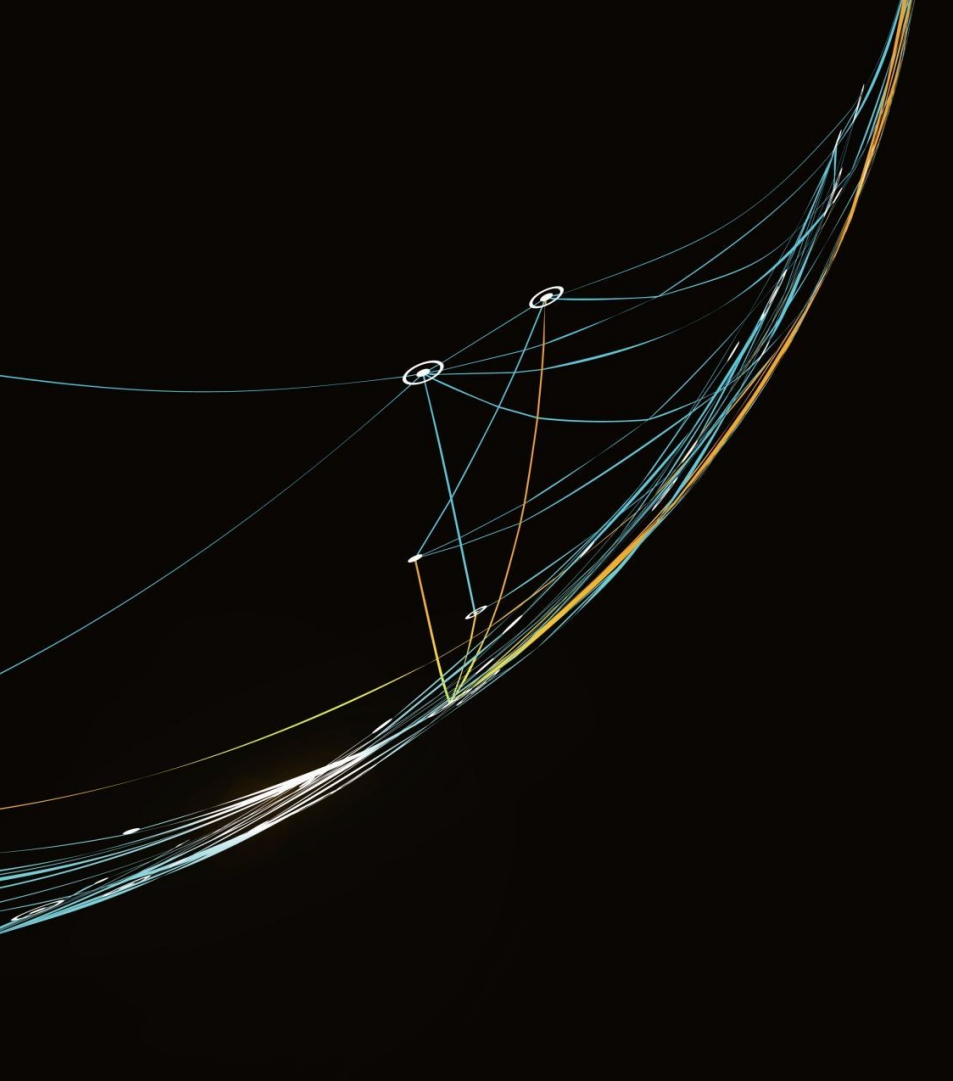
✓ **Solidarity**

- concerned with **the good of all** and **of each individual**, b/c we are all really responsible for each other, i.e. its **base is mutual obligation**. it is often **exclusive - confined to a special group**.

Cont..

✓ Citizenship

- **is the right to have rights/full members of a community.**
- Like solidarity, can be **exclusive**; it can be **used to deny people rights**, as well as to **include them**.
- Citizenship in ***autocratic societies*** Vs. Citizenship in ***plural societies***



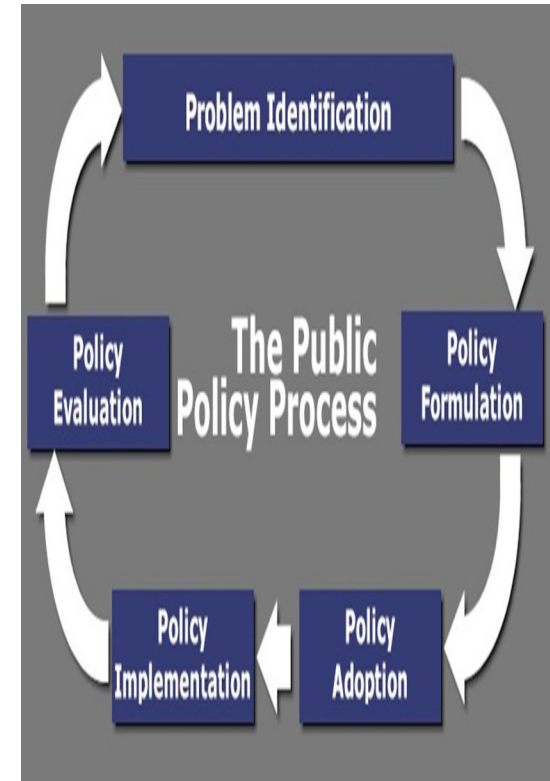
POLICY MAKING PROCESS

INTRODUCTION

- It is necessary to explicitly differentiate amongst the various stages that delimit the process of policy- making.
- This is important, since the different values and perspectives brought to bear up on each phase of the policy process can determine the definition of the issue at that point.

STAGES IN POLICY PROCESS

- The basic stages in the policy process approach include;
 1. **Problem identification (Agenda setting)**
 2. **Policy formulation,**
 3. **Policy adoption,**
 4. **Policy implementation and**
 5. **Policy evaluation.**



1. PROBLEM IDENTIFICATION (AGENDA SETTING)

- It is clear that policy- making always occurs in response to a **societal ill**.
- It aims that purposefully solving/changing something.
- The implication is that some issue in society has to be identified for amendment or improvement.
- **If there were nothing to solve, policy responses would not be necessary.**

CONT..

- However, not all troubling issues in society constitute problems to be addressed via social policy- making.
- In order to qualify as a public problem, an issue has to be;
 - 1) deemed unsatisfactory by a significant group in the public domain, and
 - 2) Something that can be addressed by government action.

WHAT IS A POLICY PROBLEM?

- A **policy problem** can be defined as a condition or situation that produces needs or dissatisfaction among people and for which relief or redress through governmental action is sought.
- **For instance;**
 - ✓ dirty air,
 - ✓ the practice of abortion,
 - ✓ urban congestion,
 - ✓ food insecurity, and
 - ✓ global warming.

CONT..

- Not all public problems make it onto the social policy agenda.
- Of the thousands and thousands of demands made upon government, only a small number will receive serious consideration by social policy- makers.
- Decisions to consider some problems mean that others will not be taken up, at least for the time being.

CONT..

- To get onto the **social policy agenda**, a problem must be converted into an issue that the government actually responds.
- **Before a policy can be created, a problem must exist that is called to the attention of the government.**

EXAMPLE

- Before a policy can be created, a problem must exist that is called to the attention of the government.
- **Illegal immigration**, for example, has been going on for many years, but it was not until the 1990s that enough people considered it such a serious problem that it required increased government action.
- Another example is **crime**. Society tolerates a certain level of crime; however, when crime rises dramatically or is perceived to be rising dramatically, it becomes an issue for policymakers to address.

EXAMPLE CONT..

- **Specific events can place a problem on the agenda.**
- For Instance; New legislation on combating **terrorism** (the USA Patriot Act, for example) was a response to the attacks of September 11, 2001.

2. POLICY FORMULATION

- **Policy formulation** means coming up with an approach to solving a problem.
- It is the stage in which the officials and bureaucrats begin to shape the issues into an acceptable format.
- This also can be a time of intense bargaining as d/t interest groups attempt to influence the language of the official response.

CONT..

- Once an issue has become a problem, and the problem has made it onto the social policy agenda, it is obligatory upon the government to strategize an appropriate response to that public problem.
- Policy formulation involves developing pertinent and acceptable proposed courses of action (often called alternatives, proposals, or options) for dealing with public problems.

CONT..

- **Policy- makers** may be challenged with several competing proposals for dealing with a problem; or they may have to struggle with devising their own alternative.
- In making choice, officials would be taking into account the policy environment and the input from various policy entrepreneurs in society.

CONT..

- The criteria applied in this last process of making choice among the alternative;
 1. **Effectiveness** (is the policy able to actually solve the problem?),
 2. **Efficiency** (how much effort will this require?),
 3. **Adequacy** (are societal needs met?),
 4. **Equity** (are these needs met across the board?),
 5. **Responsiveness** (are those most affected by the problem shielded from any negative future.
 6. **Appropriateness** (are the assumptions underlying the policy's objectives attainable?).

3. POLICY ADOPTION

- **The policy proposal is brought before the legislative branch for a formal decision.**
- It is a means of political support from the 'powers' – the government.
- Has direct correlates with decision making.

CONT..

- There are three styles of collective decision-making;
 1. **Bargaining**- involves negotiation and compromise to reach a mutually acceptable position (making the issue acceptable but not necessarily ideal for all).
 2. **Persuasion**- those in power decide on a specific policy alternative and then attempt to convince others of the correctness of the decision, thereby causing them to adopt it as their own position.

CONT..

3. **Command** - a policy decision by those in power that is then projected onto the rest of the populace without necessarily the latter's consent.

4. POLICY IMPLEMENTATION

- This stage of the policy- making process entails the translation of decisions into action.
- Comes immediately after the passage of a law- the policy on paper is turned into programs and activities “on the ground”.
- It includes defining the agencies and organizations involved and distributing responsibilities to each.
- **Effectiveness and clarity are seen here.**

CONT..

- Predominantly there are two approaches in social policy implementation;
 1. Top-down and
 2. Bottom-up approaches.

CONT..

1. **The top-down approach:** start from top leadership commitment, a high level strategy is developed, complete with vision, mission and goals.
 - Such approaches are often based on programs.
 - But the problem is it may miss the actual reality from the very beginning and also by the time it gets to the bottom, it is often interpreted very differently.

CONT..

2. Bottom-up approaches: starts from the grass root level by making individuals to be involved in the policy development process and it is more or less based on the empirical reality.

- Here it allows one to be very specific about their problems, and to create the policy that can help to tackle the problems.

KEY FEATURES OF A BOTTOM-UP APPROACH

1. Focus on the individual
2. Accountability at all levels
3. Community building
4. Leaders as Coordinators
5. Sense of Ownership

5. POLICY EVALUATION

- assessing outcomes; and fed back may be used for the agenda setting stage.
- identifies factors that contribute to the success or failure of a policy.
- it may identify shortcomings that cause the policy process to recycle (continue, modify, strengthen, or terminate a policy).

FORMS OF POLICY EVALUATION

1. Through legislators, administrators, judges, pressure-group officials, media commentators.
2. Policy evaluation centres on process, on the operation or administration of a policy or program.
3. Systematic and intended objective evaluation of programs.



Social Policy Analysis

OBJECTIVE OF SOCIAL POLICY ANALYSIS

- Here are the points;
 - ❖ To understand the origin, evolution and effectiveness of the policy
 - ❖ To understand its impacts on people
 - ❖ To consider what exists and what alternatives there might be
 - ❖ To think about other needs that might be anticipated
 - ❖ To look for negative consequences of policies, even if they are useful
 - ❖ To foster the development of the discipline

TYPE OF SOCIAL POLICY ANALYSIS

- Can be divided into two major fields:
 1. **Analysis of existing policy**
 2. **Analysis for new policy**

1. ANALYSIS OF EXISTING POLICY

- AofEP evaluates the design, implementation and effects of existing social policy.
- AofEP can be:
 - **Structural**-What the policy contains—how it will work—what elements are included in THIS policy and perhaps not in others or
 - **Process**-How the policy came about—what forces drove it and/or tried to stop it or both types for more analysis.
- It may use the tools and research methods of economics, sociology, political science and other disciplines to examine policy.

2.ANALYSIS FOR NEW POLICY

- Analysis for new policy includes;
 - defines the problem or issue at hand,
 - describes its background,
 - provides a balanced assessment of options that policy makers could pursue to resolve the problem, and
 - recommends course of action for policy makers.

Relationship between Policy and Plan

What is the relationship between policy and plan ?

Cont..

- Planning and policy making are **closely related**.
- Planner should have some understanding of the policy decisions which s/he is trying to implement.
- One may say that **policy making** means making **decision about the type of change or development which is required**,
- While **planning** is the process of **deciding how best to bring about this change or development**.

Cont..

- Policies are **realized through plans**, which in turn are implemented through regularly applied procedures.
- In most cases the actual policy decision will be made by the **politicians** rather than by the planners.
- However this decision will be based on information and alternatives presented by planning staff.
- Thus, **planning is viewed not as an isolated activity but as part of a complex process of policy.**

Cont..

- Planning involves **making decisions or choices** about how best to use available resources to achieve particular aims or objectives.
- **It may includes;**
 - 1.The identification of goals or objectives (policy)
 - 2.The formulation of broad development strategies
 - 3.The translation of the strategies in to specific programs and projects.
 - 4.The implementation of these programs and projects
 - 5.Monitoring the implementation and evaluating the impact

The Difference

policy

- **Key characteristics of a policy include:**

- It describes principles.
- It addresses the "what" and "why."
- It has broad application.
- It is expressed in a broad, inclusive manner.
- It changes infrequently in response to newly emerging issues, changing relationships or alterations to the institutional mission or philosophy.

Plan

- **Key characteristics of a plan include:**
 - It addresses the question of "how" to carry out a policy.
 - It is carried out with an initial investment of time and resources.
 - It is often involve timeline and budget chosen
 - technology and process employed.

Social planning approaches

Cont..

- Predominantly there are **three approaches** in social planning which are;
 - 1. Centralized planning**
 - 2. Decentralized planning**
 - 3. Mixed Economy planning**

1. Centralized planning

- Is practiced in **command Economies**.
- The state controls through directives and regulations the following things:
 - Level of savings
 - Amount and composition of output and investment
 - The structure of prices.

Cont..

■ What are the practices of Central planning authorities?

- ☐ Issue detailed directives and instructions to enterprises.
- ☐ Specify what and how much they have to produce.
- ☐ The raw materials and supplies are regulated by price settings.
- ☐ The amount of labor required, how costs are to be determined, what prices to be charged for products, and where it is to be delivered, what investments are to be made, etc are **determined at the centre.**

- Such type of planning is said to be appropriate at the **early stage of development.**

Advantages

1. It can **conserve scarce resources** or ensure the efficient allocation of scarce resources for development and
2. Help **transform the social and economic structure.**

Disadvantages

1. **Scarcity of important commodities is observed** in centrally planned economies. Thus, central controlling of every aspect of enterprise operations, initiative, creativity and reduce quality of products.
 2. **The allocation of resources to different sectors of industries will be distorted (unfair)**; consumption and capital investment targets will not be balanced.
- So, central planning has failed in many instances and countries abandon the exercise of central planning like **Yugoslavia, Poland, USSR, Czechoslovakia**.

2. Decentralized planning

- It is practiced in countries with market economies such as **USA, Japan, UK** etc.
- In these countries planning plays vital roles in the economy, although it is **done relatively indirectly**.
- Governments make conscious efforts to attain rapid economic growth, high employment and stable prices through various **fiscal** and **monetary policies**.
 - **Monetary policy** refers to central bank activities that are directed toward influencing the quantity of money and credit in an economy.
 - **fiscal policy** refers to the government's decisions about taxation and spending.

Cont..

- Governments have realized that they should **not leave the economy to market forces**, The **market does not govern the economy completely**.
- Governments have to play roles to create conducive conditions that would prevent economic instability through policy instruments including.
 1. Expansionary monetary policy
 2. Increased government spending
 3. Tax rate adjustment

■ .

Cont..

- Such policy instruments are **indirect but active measures** to dictate the economy in the desired direction
- They are **indirect because they create favourable conditions** that influence private decision makers without direct involvement in the economy.
- Decentralized planning do **not involve in detailed development planning.**

3. Mixed Economy planning

- Most of the **third world countries** are referred to as mixed economies.
- In such countries a **substantial portion of the economy** is owned and controlled by the public sector, and the remaining part is controlled privately.

Cont..

- In this institutional arrangement we can identify **two principal components of development planning**.
 1. Government's deliberate utilization of domestic savings and foreign finance to carry out public investment projects and to mobilize and channel scarce resources to achieve long-term objectives.
 2. Government policies like taxation, import quota, wage and prices policy, etc which are designed to stimulate, direct or to control private economic activities.
- This is done to create harmonious relationships between the private businessmen's desire and social objectives of the central government.

The end